

plug-in support as Android's native video support is patchy. Things have improved with Ice Cream Sandwich and Jelly Bean but more is expected from the next version.

GNOME to develop its own OS

In a bid to catch up with the rest, the GNOME Desktop Project team is now working to develop its own operating system. The announcement about the GNOME OS was made by Allan Day, a user interface developer with Red Hat. The GNOME OS is supposed to be an option for tablets and mobile phones. It is worth mentioning here that Mozilla is also working to bring out its open source mobile OS.

It's good to see GNOME finally taking a call regarding the growing mobile and tablet markets but it would be interesting to see how long the project takes to become a reality. GNOME has been on the back foot ever since it was dropped by Canonical in April 2011, to be replaced by Unity in Ubuntu 11.04.

According to Day, the GNOME OS aims at "...providing a better experience for application developers, automated testing, sandboxed applications, and broad hardware compatibility" and the team hopes to improve the GNOME desktop that will ultimately be made available for use by other distros.

The world's first NFC keyboard for Android smartphones

Japanese electronics company, Elecom, has come up with an NFC-enabled portable keyboard which is designed for Android smartphones. It uses the radio frequency of the 13.56 MHz band and can be used by Android phone users at a distance of about 10 mm.



Once the initial software installation and configuration is completed, users just need to place their NFC-enabled Android device onto the space in the middle of the keyboard and start typing.

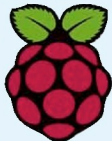
The device includes a built-in battery that is neither rechargeable nor replaceable. According to the company, it will last for 18 months if used for eight hours per day. So users will have no choice but to go for a replacement keyboard after that.

The 34 cm, 45-key keyboard is made of silicon. It can be folded away into a compact carrying case. At 144g, the keyboard comes with a retail price of approximately \$240. It has been designed in collaboration with Norwegian firm, One2Touch.

The company has not disclosed any plans on when or whether the keyboard will be launched outside Japan.

Gertboard expansion board for Raspberry Pi

If you want to make your Raspberry Pi a powerful device, way beyond just a PC, you now can with Gertboard, which enables you to use Raspberry Pi as the brain of a robot, digital signage system or for many other such tasks.



The credit-card sized PC is powered by a 700 MHz ARM1111 processor and comes with 256 MB of memory and an SD card slot for storage. It can run a desktop Linux-based operating system and users can connect it to a keyboard, mouse, Ethernet cable and monitor to make it a full-fledged PC.

But Gertboard can also add sensors, and input and output options to the computer. At the time of introducing Raspberry Pi, the developers also revealed Gertboard, which is an expansion board to add support for sensors, LEDs, motors and other peripherals.

Gertboard gets its name from its developer, Gert van Loo. The Raspberry Pi team has showcased the new version of the Gertboard on the company's blog, with a number of updates and improvements. An official announcement, about Gertboard being ready to go on sale and at what cost, is expected soon.

Gertboard will help transform the Raspberry Pi from a low-cost computer to something similar to an Arduino board used for building robots, musical instruments, thermostats, security alarms or other devices.